Pressing this colorful, zingy soup through a strainer may seem tedious, but it does wonders for the texture and is worth the effort.

carrot cream with onion and cumin

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS
BEFORE HALF-AND-HALF IS ADDED

2 tbsp sunflower or olive oil
2 large Spanish onions, peeled and coarsely chopped
1 tsp cumin seeds
1 tsp ground cumin
2¼lb (1kg) carrots, peeled and coarsely chopped
sea salt and freshly ground black pepper
juice and grated zest of 1 small unwaxed orange
½ cup half-and-half
1 tbsp finely chopped flat-leaf parsley

1 Place a large sauté pan over medium-high heat. Add the oil and stir in the onion and cumin. Cook for 3–5 minutes, or until softened, stirring frequently. Add the carrots and 1½ quarts (1½ liters) water, then season lightly with salt and pepper. Bring to a boil, reduce the heat, cover, and simmer gently for 20 minutes, or until the carrots are very tender. Turn off the heat and let cool a little.

2 Pour into a blender or food processor and process until smooth. Place a strainer over a saucepan (or the sauté pan if possible). Pour the soup into the strainer and press it through with the back of a wooden spoon.

3 Taste and adjust the seasoning. Stir in the orange juice and zest. Reheat until piping hot and stir in the half-and-half, then the parsley. Season with a little extra pepper. Serve hot.